Chapter 21 – Wildlife, Then and Now

“The greatness of a nation and its moral progress can be judged by the way its animals are treated.”

(Mohandas Gandhi)

Though the initial placement of the Indian National Congress in power over the new Dominion was temporary, it was officially voted into that same office following the country’s first democratic election. It was an important step not only toward the better organization of the country’s resources and infrastructure but toward more complex forms of self-care. There were a great many ways in which the new India hoped to better itself, and that included finding ways to care for the physical landscape and the creatures that dwelled within the Dominion of India.

The flora and fauna of the Indian subcontinent are just as splendid, diverse, and amazing as the people and the culture. Ten thousand years ago, massive woolly mammoths roamed the land and began to evolve into a beloved member of this part of the world: the Indian elephant. A sub-species of the larger Asian elephant, these elephants have shared their ancestral home with an array of fascinating creatures, from the Bengal tiger and the Indian rhinoceros to the snow leopard and the peacock. Several millennia spent alongside India’s human communities has had perhaps the most lasting influence on these wildlife populations.

We’ve already discussed the fates of those great elephants who became the pets and favored warriors of India’s earliest tribes. Trained from infancy to follow the commands of their human masters, hundreds of thousands of Asian elephants helped shape the political landscape of the ancient subcontinent. They were the pride of the Mauryan Army and the Mughal Army; even the East India Company had 1,500 war elephants in its military armory that were used during the Sepoy Rebellion of 1857. Though the use of war elephants declined in the 20th century, elephants remained useful during the Second World War when British India used them to help transport building materials and manipulate logs for road and bridge building.